Visual storytelling plan

WrestleCraft: Be The Booker (repo ryanblanchettegl/batman) · 21 October 2026 · design only, no code changed yet

The short version

The game already has a strong picture engine: the paper diorama (`kit/scene.ts` , `kit/puppet.ts` , `ScenePlayer`). It draws every wrestler from their own Create a Player look, plays a scene for every match moment, promo, angle and entrance, and already knows how to put a title belt over a champion's shoulder. Today most of that only shows up in two places: the broadcast window and the Roster file. The rankings, the Titles page, the Web sites, History and the show's opening are still words and tables.

So the plan is mostly about **pointing the engine we have at more screens**, not building a new one. Almost every idea below reuses three things that already exist:

- **Champions already wear their gold.** A wrestler's recipe takes `belts` and `beltL` (`kit/puppet.ts` , around line 433): the first belt goes over the shoulder, the second round the waist, the third over the other shoulder, each drawn as that title's own belt from Create a Belt. Entrances (`Live.tsx`) and the Roster file (`Roster.tsx` line 89) use it. Portraits and everything else do not.
- **Still pictures are cheap.** `PaperPortrait` paints a doll once and caches the canvas, so ten portraits on a page cost ten draws, once. `ScenePlayer` with `still` gives a full-length picture.
- **Templates exist.** Create a Scene already has a poster, a magazine cover, a video game cover, an action shot, a portrait and "the champion with the belt" (`TEMPLATES` in `kit/scene.ts`). Captions include a lower third and a title card (`CAP_STYLES`).

Phase 1: champions and rankings you can see

1. Champions carry their belt in every portrait (small)

What the player sees: anywhere a champion's face shows (run sheet, the vs strip on the broadcast, the desk, the feed, contenders lists), they have the belt over their shoulder, in that title's own colours.

How: move the inline code in `Roster.tsx:89` into one helper, `champRecipe(w, P)` in `kit/portrait.tsx`, and have `Portrait` use it. The shoulder plate sits on the chest, so the existing "To the chest" frame shows it; for head-and-shoulders portraits, a champion gets the chest frame automatically. The portrait cache key already includes the recipe, so a title change redraws on its own.

Test: `app/tests/roster.js` gains a check that a champion's portrait differs from the same wrestler's without the title.

2. The Titles page becomes a wall of champions (medium)

What the player sees: the table stays, but above it (or as its own window, "The champions") each title is a cut-card panel: the champion full length with the belt on the shoulder, arms crossed, the title's name in marker on a strip of black card, and the reign in weeks and defences under it. A tag title shows both partners, each with a belt. A vacant title shows the belt alone on a stand with VACANT across it.

How: a new still, `champ_shoulder`, alongside the `champ` template (pose `CROSS`, set `plain` or the company's backdrop, square frame). Cast with `champRecipe`. One `ScenePlayer still` per title is fine at 1080p, so the wall is the page's main window and shows every title at once in a grid. Rule 5b (one screen) holds because the panels replace the Contenders window's top half, and contenders move into a pop-up per title (rule 6a).

Test: a new `app/tests/titles.js` (or extend `roster.js`): every held title has a picture, a vacant title shows VACANT, and the page still fits (`fits()`).

3. The Power Ten board (medium)

What the player sees: a proper top ten, like a magazine's rankings page. Number one stands full length on the left, wearing whatever gold they hold, with "No. 1" in big marker. Numbers two to ten are large index cards in a three by three grid that fills the rest of the screen: chest portrait, rank number, name, company logo chip, and a red or green arrow with how far they moved. Clicking a card opens their file.

Where it lives: the World page (replacing the text `PowerTen` in `company/World.tsx`) and the Top Ten Tuesday site on the Web (`Rankings` in `net/Search.tsx`, which uses `E.criticList`). The engine side is done: `E.power(S, 10)` and `E.powerWas()` already give the list and the movement.

Optional extra: each title's contender top five (`E.rankFor`) as a smaller board of the same cards on the title's pop-up.

Test: the board shows ten cards with portraits, number one has a full-length picture, arrows match `E.powerWas`. Never calls `rnd(S)`.

Phase 2: the broadcast tells the story in pictures

All of these respect the Scenes on/off switch (`pref.pics`) and reduced motion, and none change the result of anything.

4. Show open: the poster, not a text card

Today the opening (`TitleCard` in `Live.tsx`) is text. Swap in the main event's poster (the same `PosterPic` the desk already shows for the next show), with the show's name as the masthead and the company logo in the corner. Big events get the tall poster frame.

5. Tale of the tape before a title match or main event

Before the bell, one still: both wrestlers' chest portraits face to face, the belt between them, and a few lines under each: record against each other (`S.h2h`), weeks as champion, finisher, the crowd's side. It is a lower-third style card, so it sits on the broadcast frame without a new layout.

6. "Previously on" for a feud match

Every story beat already has a scene (`beat_<beat>`, `BEAT_SCENES`). Before a match in a living storyline, show up to three stills of that feud's last beats as a comic strip ("Two weeks ago: the attack. Last week: the contract signing."). This is the strongest piece of visual storytelling we can add, because it ties the show to the Storylines page.

7. The new champion's moment, kept

The `champion` scene already plays when a title changes. Add a closing still of the new champion with the belt over the shoulder and a title card ("AND NEW"), and use that same picture on After the show, on the Titles wall, and as the photo for that week's dirt sheet headline.

8. Tonight's moments as a strip at the sign-off

`Moments` in `Live.tsx` lists the night's three biggest moments as text. Draw each as a small still (the near fall, the finish, the new champion) in a three-panel strip.

Phase 3: the world remembers in pictures

9. Big event posters

Every big event (`P.events`) gets a poster four weeks out: the main event face to face, the event's name as the masthead. It shows on the desk and the Web. After the event, the poster goes on a wall in History. This is the open task "Create a Poster or Cover" in `TASKS.md`.

10. A monthly magazine cover

Once a month, the month's top wrestler on a magazine cover (the `mag` template) with a headline from the text grammar (`GR_SHEET` style). Shown on the Web page and kept as a gallery in History. Year end: a "Wrestler of the year" cover.

11. The title's lineage as portraits

The Lineage window on the Titles page becomes a row of small portraits, each champion holding that belt, with reign length under each. History keeps the full line.

12. Trading card on a wrestler's file

A tall card with the wrestler in their entrance gear, their overall badge, finisher and title, for the Roster file and the World Editor. It doubles as a share image later for the Steam Workshop.

13. Match of the year, with pictures

`S.moty` already keeps the year's best matches. Show its top ten on the Web with an action-shot still of each, cast with the two who fought.

Rules this has to follow

- Rule 2a, the hand-made look: every board is cut card and paper, numbers in marker, no dot matrix.
- Designed at 1080p as the base, and every board scales up to the main modern resolutions: 1440p, ultrawide and 4K (Bill, 22 October). No Steam Deck or tablet. Boards use the whole screen and are laid out in grid fractions, not fixed pixels. Pictures are painted at the size they show on screen, so a 4K portrait stays sharp. Lists still use cached portraits so pages draw quickly.

- Rule 5b: one screen, no page scrolling. Boards replace windows, they do not add to them.
- Rule 5: every card is a real button with a `data-t` name, reachable by mouse, keys and pad.
- Pictures only read the game. No `rnd(S)`, so a picture can never change how a game plays.
- Rule 9a: one step at a time, with a look at the result before the next.

Suggested order

1. Champions carry their belt in every portrait. Small, and it lifts every other idea.
2. The Power Ten board.
3. The Titles wall of champions.
4. Tale of the tape and "Previously on" on the broadcast.
5. Posters, covers and the History galleries.

Each step is one small pull request with its browser test, a version bump once five are in (rule 10a), and the live build pushed after it passes.